PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY MARK SCHEME

2025 Exam-Style Practice Paper

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75 (1HI0/33)

Question 1: Inference from Source A (4 Marks)

Target: AO3 (4 marks). Award 1 mark for each valid inference, up to 2. Award 1 mark for each corresponding quote/detail, up to 2.

Sample Acceptable Inferences (communist supply lines along the Ho Chi Minh Trail in 1965):

• **Inference 1:** The natural jungle terrain effectively hid communist troop movements and supplies from American air detection.

- *Detail from source:* "Porters and supply convoys move under dense double-canopy jungle that completely conceals them from our reconnaissance aircraft."

• **Inference 2:** US air strikes were unable to stop the sharp increase in supplies moving into South Vietnam.

- *Detail from source:* "The flow of communist troops and war supplies along the Ho Chi Minh Trail has escalated sharply... Despite thousands of air strikes, the supply route remains unbroken."

Question 2: Causal Explanation (12 Marks)

Target: AO1/AO2 (12 marks). Level 4 (10–12 marks): An analytical explanation showing a line of reasoning with clear links to the outcome, supported by accurate, detailed knowledge.

"One reason why the Montgomery Bus Boycott (1955–56) was successful was the outstanding local organisation by the Montgomery Improvement Association (MIA)." Instead of using buses, the MIA organised a complex and highly effective **carpool system** involving over 300 vehicles, alongside reduced-fare taxi rides from Black drivers, to ensure that Black workers could still travel to their jobs. This was kickstarted by **Jo Ann Robinson** distributing 35,000 leaflets. *Therefore, the boycott was successful because this logistical network allowed the Black community to sustain the boycott for **381 days** without being starved into submission by the city's authorities.*

"Another reason why it was successful was the severe economic pressure the boycott placed on local authorities and businesses." Because Black Americans made up roughly **70%** of bus riders in Montgomery, their year-long refusal to pay fares threatened the local bus company with bankruptcy and damaged downtown merchants. This solidarity was solidified by the respect for **Rosa Parks**, whose arrest united the community. *Therefore, this led to success because the city authorities simply could not afford to maintain segregation if it meant the total financial ruin of their transport system.*

"A final reason for its success was the parallel legal strategy that reached the highest courts." While the boycott applied economic pressure on the streets, the **NAACP** successfully took the case to the federal courts. In 1956, the US Supreme Court upheld the ruling in **Browder v. Gayle**, definitively declaring that segregation on Montgomery buses was unconstitutional based on the precedent set by the **Brown v. Topeka** case. *Therefore, the boycott ultimately succeeded because the Supreme Court forced the state of Alabama to legally change its discriminatory laws, overriding local resistance.*

In conclusion, the boycott was successful because the sheer economic endurance and organisation of the grassroots movement gave civil rights lawyers the time and leverage needed to win the ultimate legal victory in the Supreme Court.

Question 3(a): Source Utility (8 Marks)

Target: AO3 (8 marks). Assess content utility, verify with contextual knowledge, and evaluate provenance reliability and limitations for BOTH sources.

Source B is highly useful for showing the early stages of US escalation in Vietnam under President Kennedy through military and economic advising. The document details that the USA authorized transport helicopters and air support, dispatch of US personnel for aerial reconnaissance, training programs, and military and administrative advisers. This content is highly useful because it aligns with my knowledge that Kennedy increased the number of US military advisers from around 800 in 1961 to over 16,000 by 1963, and supplied helicopters to transport South Vietnamese troops, demonstrating a clear step towards direct involvement. The provenance of a declassified memo from 1961 makes it extremely useful because it represents the actual, confidential policy decisions of the Kennedy administration at the beginning of the decade, revealing their hidden plans to shore up South Vietnam without the filter of public diplomacy.

Source C is highly useful for showing the dramatic transition to large-scale combat operations and the mobilization of the US population under President Johnson. Johnson announces that he has ordered additional units to deploy, raising strength to 125,000 troops, plans to send additional forces as requested by General Westmoreland, and will increase the military draft to support this. This content's utility is supported by my knowledge that in July 1965, Johnson made the pivotal decision to commit US ground forces to active combat, causing US troop levels to surpass 184,000 by the end of 1965 and peaking at over 536,000 by 1968, backed by draft call-ups. The provenance of a public television broadcast to the American people in July 1965 makes the source highly useful for understanding how the president publicly justified this massive expansion of the war, framing it as a necessary response to keep our commitments, though it is limited because it downplays the expected casualties and financial costs of the conflict.

Question 3(b): Difference Between Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Identify the main difference of view, supported by details from both interpretations.

The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that Kennedy's decisions in 1961 were a **"key phase in the escalation"** of US involvement. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that President Johnson was **"primarily responsible for converting"** the conflict into an active combat war.

Question 3(c): Reason for Difference in Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Explain how the historians may have relied on different sources to reach their views.

The interpretations differ because the historians have given weight to different sources. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source B, which lists early aid and "military and administrative advisers", leading to the view that Kennedy's 1961 decisions were a **"key phase in the escalation"**. Conversely, Interpretation 2 is supported by Source C, which ordered troop deployments raising strength to "125,000 troops", leading to the view that Johnson was **"primarily responsible for converting"** the war into an active combat war.

Question 3(d): Evaluation of Interpretation (16 Marks + 4 SPaG)

Target: AO4 (16 marks) + SPaG (4 marks). Level 4 (13–16 marks): Balanced discussion analyzing both interpretations with sustained contextual knowledge, leading to a justified judgment.

I agree to a large extent with Interpretation 2 that President Johnson was the president most responsible for the combat escalation of the war. After the **1964 Gulf of Tonkin incident**, Johnson secured the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, which gave him a blank check to wage war. As broadcast in Source C, Johnson ordered additional units to Vietnam, raising fighting strength to **125,000** troops, and increased the number of men called up by the **draft system**. This transformed Vietnam from an advisory mission into an active combat war, supporting Interpretation 2's view that Johnson was **"primarily responsible for converting"** the conflict into an **"active combat war"**.

However, Interpretation 1 is also valid in identifying Kennedy's administration as the initial, critical turning point. As detailed in the declassified memo in Source B, Kennedy approved **transport helicopters**, reconnaissance, and **military and administrative advisers**. Under Kennedy, advisers rose from under 1,000 to over **16,000** by 1963, and he approved the use of chemical defoliants like **Agent Orange**. This supports Interpretation 1's argument that Kennedy's 1961 decisions were a **"key phase in the escalation"** that **"marked a key phase"** in expanding the US role.

Overall, while Kennedy made the crucial decisions that committed the US militarily (Interpretation 1), it was Johnson who took the decisive step of initiating a direct, large-scale American ground war (Interpretation 2). Until Johnson deployed combat troops and began bombing North Vietnam, the US role was theoretically advisory. Therefore, Interpretation 2 is the stronger explanation because Johnson's policies fundamentally changed the nature of the conflict into an American war.